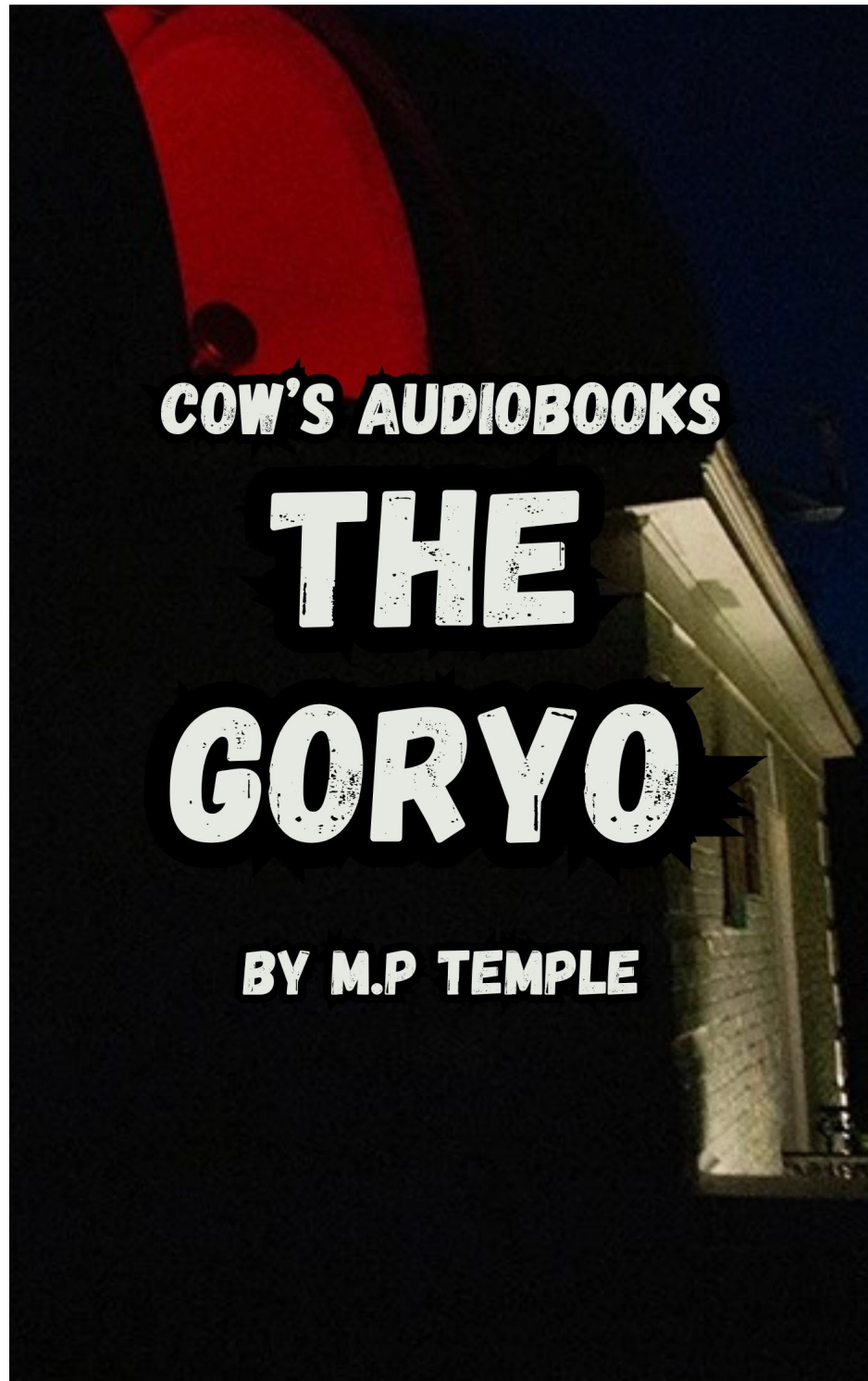




Everyone Welcome Missouri. October 2026.

The young adult could only watch as the preacher wheeled in a giant tv cart, attached with a VHS player. He pressed in the tape labelled ‘Pastor Branson Exposed!’ and hit the play button.

“How did you get that?” Nael asked. “I haven’t released that video yet...”

Pastor Branson did not answer him. Instead he crossed his arms and pointed with his lips at the tv, now playing Nael’s unreleased documentary.

“In this episode of Justice with Nael, we investigated some supposed ghosts haunting at Everyone Welcome Baptist church in a Missouri river town. But instead of Casper and Pals, we found something darker. We found the minister in charge of an illegal underground betting ring. What were they betting on? Cow races. I found people from all over the state at these ‘private raffles’. So to stop this injustice, I stole all the cows and released them back into the wild. Then we hacked into their bank account and drained all the money they earned from the betting. Now we are going to vote on who I am giving the money to. Before that, we need to start back at the beginning. Don’t forget to like and subscribe!”

The preacher stopped the video and stared at the young

man with curly hair.

Nael raised his hand. “I have one question. Why is it on VHS tape?”

The preacher scoffed. “If you, or GTA6, stored your information on tape it wouldn’t have been leaked would it? Not so out dated tech is it? How about we talk about the police charges I plan to fill on you. Would you like to count along with me how many years in prison time you are facing?”

“Me in jail? You should look at yourself, old man. You were torturing those poor cows by making them train and race...”

“Let me finish. Would you like it presented as a math problem, or would you like to accept a video assignment I’d like you to do instead? About a real ghost sighting at a Fayette observatory?”

“I started the channel to expose frauds like you. Ghosts are not real,” Nael said.

“I’ve seen your video on blowing the roof off the Winchester mansion, I know well of your ignorance on the topic. I need to know it is real. If so, what is causing it? I’d do it myself, but my duties to the community lie in

other places and times. Go there. And report back to me what you find out.”

Neal stood up in protest. “Isn’t that the fifth commandment or whatever? Thou shall not blackmail?”

Pastor Branson walked in front of the door, blocking Neal’s path to the exit.

“Instead of whatever you think it is you are accusing me of, consider how well you would do in a jail. Serving fifteen years for every valuable race cow stolen. All of which we recovered, by the way.”

Neal dashed to the TV cart and removed the tape from the player. The preacher didn’t as much as flinch at seeing this.

“I have copies you know. Even if you release the video now, I have video evidence. You would stand no chance in court. Checking out this ghost thing for me would be much easier, and would take up a considerably less amount of your time.”

“Fine,” Neal put the video on the preachers desk. “I’ll go to Fayette and I’ll reveal this fraud there. And after that? I will do everything legally to figuratively destroy you. Because you are evil.”

The preacher shook his head. “Here is some free advice, young man. Although I do not agree with your assessment of me or my services to the communities I work for, know this. Evil can not be destroyed. Every attempt further spreads the evil you deem to vanish until it is out of your reach. Evil can only be pacified. And for the record, I’m not afraid of losing my power. You may think me evil, but believe you me I am pacified. And that is why I am not evil.”

“You’ll see your day in court soon enough.” Neal said. He left the room, slamming the door behind him.



Morrison Observatory

The audio tapes were recording, and the dozens of laser beams were scattered across the wood floor in the circle shaped room. Nael checked his hair again on his phone’s camera before starting the video.

“What’s up, friends?! This is Nael for Justice, and in today’s video, we are exposing whoever it is pretending to be a ghost in Fayette Missouri. This work study chick

told me that students have reported electronic devices like phones and laptops going out when around the observatory or classroom. Before we get into it, I want to thank the video's sponsor. Massive Headache! The band out of southern North Dakota is heating it up with their new hit single 'We Hate Music'! I'm going to play a clip so you can get as excited as I am and buy an album. [a few seconds of silence] Now that's what I call a statement! Now. Back to the video. Let's get into it."

Before he could continue, the telescope and the room began to change position on it's own.

"Woah," Nael said, staring at the reflector telescope. The computer attached to it began to blink pink and white, colours it did not have.

"This is obviously some trick someone programed to happen when I was in the room. So instead of some supernatural spirit, this is some super natural fraud! This means that work study chick or maybe the telescope teacher dude is in on it!"

The lights started to flicker. All of his LED ghost lights burst into flames with a violent crack. The power went out, and Nael was left standing in the dark.

Nael shook his head. "I've seen it ghost bro. Like this is

so stereotypical! You're not fooling me. Oh no, you can turn off some lights! I'm shaking. You know what? Even if you are a spirit? I bet you are a total wuss. You couldn't harm anything if you tried! Even if you weren't dead! So, show me something actually scary!"

A light shot out of the telescope's eyepiece. Illuminating the white walls, turning them the colour of blood. From inside the telescope, he heard the screams and clanging of swords.

"Actually," Nael said, backing toward the exit, "Prison can't be that bad. I'm just really to have to bulk up..."

The man ran to the door and turned the knob. But the door did not open. Something was holding it shut. Nael kicked and hit as hard as he could. But there was no escape.

A voice resonating from somewhere in the room rang out "Do not challenge my honour then flee. I command you to look into the star machine."

"No, I think I'm good. I got a date to get to and..."

A bolt of lightning struck the telescope. When it hit, a crack rang out so loud that ground shook.

"LOOK!" The voice shouted as if a war cry.

Nael crept slowly to the view finder and looked inside. Instead of a star or planet, he saw the upside image of a beach. Surrounded by steep cliffs full of tea. The crops looked brown and hardly alive. Before Nael could make some snide comment, a severed head rolled into view. Nael backed away from the telescope and went back into the darkness.

“That was the last man I killed in life. A skuller.”

“Woah buddy, that’s I don’t know what that is but I know a slur when I hear one.”

“SILENCE!”

Something fell onto Nael’s head. He turned on the flash on his phone and pointed at his feet. There he saw another head. Next to it another one appeared. Then another. And another. The round room filled with heads, some even of women.

“These are the foe’s that I have slain for my clan. I have been heavily rewarded for each. The only reason I failed is because that skuller struck me with her powers. I could have been the one to unite us all. Instead, I am here. Seeing some painted person loudly talking about hipster music! If you think you can best me, then challenge me. Yoha the beheader. I will end you.”

“I’ll be leaving now actually” Nael said, jumping up to the bleachers in the room. “I got a dog... errr. Hamster to take out and...”

The wood of the bleachers snapped, sending Nael crashing to the floor. That’s when he saw two ghostly swords appear and a figure fly from below the floor. A ghastly warrior in blue samurai gear picked up one of the swords and pressed the tip to Nael’s forehead. The blade was cold, sharp and real.

Nael started to cry. “Look bro I’m just doing a youtube video, I don’t know this stuff was real! Let me go! I’m american, we haven’t done anything bad to your country.... Oh... I mean” Nael started to curse. “Spare me! Please!”

“Why do you think your life is worth more than any of the people’s heads around you! Wipe your tears, you coward, and die!”

The ghost pulled back the sword high, reading to strike. But a knock came at the door. Pastor Branson shouted from outside “Nael! If you’re in there come out, I’ve heard the news and I am pulling you from the assignment! Open up!”

The ghost lowered the sword. “Tonight has brought you

luck. But after eight hundred years I have defeated my greatest foe. ENGLISH! AND NOW I WILL HAVE MY REVENGE!”

The door of the observatory flung open with a swift kick. The ghost, and all the heads disappeared. Pastor Branson flipped on the lights, which powered back on. Nael was on the floor, curled into a ball, still sweeping.

“What’s wrong! What did you see?” Pastor Branson rushed to his side.

“I... I... I saw a totally evil bro dude.”

“Forget you ever came here.” Said Pastor Branson “After I learned someone saw an actual head, I came here as fast as I could. Go. Leave this place. Delete the video Any issues we have against each other are settled.”



C bench, Central Methodist University

Nael tried calling Pastor Branson for the fifth time with no answer.

“This is so stupid,” he said switching to the camera app. He started recording and put on a smile.

“Yo, I don’t know what video this is going into, but

something is seriously up in Fayette. For the first time in my life, maybe ever, I saw a ghost! And it tried to kill me! He almost did! That's how I got this mark on my forehead. And that's why I'm never coming back to CMU again! Cause this is no longer my idea. I'm going home! I..."

A college woman ran into the shot, clapping her hands together. Nael screamed in horror, and curled into a ball again.

"Oh my Omaha!" The woman said, trying to help him up. "I know who you are! It's Nael for Justice! I love you! We should hang out. And marry!"

Nael feel silent. His heart sunk. He stood to his feet.

"Bro. That is the second creepiest thing that's happened to me today." He said. "I don't mean it like that... I.. Hold on."

He switched app's, while still recording to the phone contacts. He found the entry labelled "Don't apologise" and dialled it. Someone answered.

"Hey sorry to bug." Nael said. "It's... happening again... I tried to explain but... yeah. You know. Can you do the thing again? Thanks, I'm putting you on speaker. I have a

friend who needs to talk to you.”

He pointed the phone at the woman, who had her hands out in a shrugging gesture.

A woman spoke through the phone. “Hi. This is Nael’s ex. I know life seems hard right now. This seems like it’s the easy way out. But you’re not alone. Things can get better. Nael means well. He isn’t physical or emotionally abusive. But he is like a very small puppy. Who can’t be house trained. Accidents are going to happen, and they are going to be messy. That is not a life that I wish upon anyone. That is why I hold seminars on Thursdays about...”

“Hey!” Nael cried out. “You told me you would stop the support groups for people who expressed any interest in me.”

“I’m just raising awareness.” The woman said. “Anyways, Nael is the type who knows he has demons within. But he refuses to fight them. He lets them grow and grow until they turn into some giant creature from hell that can’t be stopped. The demon move right into places they don’t belong. He knows he struggles to say anything to this bad stuff going on and is incapable of facing his demons. That is why you should smile. Say

goodbye, and walk away. As fast as you can. Godspeed.”

The woman thought for a moment, then said. “Goodbye.” She walked away, though some might argue it was more of a run.

“You are the best. And you’re right. Maybe it is about time I face my inner Samurai ghost. Like the one I found in the Observatory that tried to kill me. Even though Branson told me to stay away and not get involved. Thanks for the clarity bro.” He said.

“Stop calling me bro. And WHAT?! You found a real Samurai ghost! If that is true, don’t go back! Those are actually called...”

“Got to go, I got to find a way to get Yoha the Beheader to cross over. Peace bro.” Nael ended the call.



Morrison Observatory

Books now were scattered near the telescope. With titles such as “A Grief Observed”, “Coping with Death” and “How to Cross Over for dimwits”.

Only after laying out all the material did Nael attempt to contact the spirit. “Oh! Yoha the Beheader. I have

returned. Not to finish my challenge. But to help you heal and cope with the being dead thing. We can talk about anything in these books I put out.”

Only silence followed. Until two swords appeared in front of Nael’s feet.

“I think you misunderstood,” He said, looking around. “I’m trying to help YOU cross over. I don’t need help myself in the whole death thing? I want to help you with your unfinished business”.

Yoha the beheader appeared in front of him. The warrior picked up the sword. “I hear you want to help me? Because my current unfinished business is cutting off your head.”

“I totally get we have different goals,” Nael said, backing away. “But I’m not fighting you. And there is no honour in striking an unarmed dude bro. Don’t you have a warrior code or something?”

Yoha swung his sword at Nael, catching the edge of what was left of the wooden bleachers. He ran as the spirit charged towards him.

“Why are you so obsessed with honour?” Screamed the Samurai. “You are the one who challenged me! Now

admit to defeat or die!”

“I can agree to only one of those two things! I can see now that I was wrong.”

“Wrong choice!” Yoha swung again. Nael tossed a box at the ghost blocking what would have been a fetal blow. A box labeled “Meteorite test” with the instructions underneath “Which of these are not a meteorite?” The contents skipped along the wooden floor like rocks flung across a lake.

One of the rod shaped stones looked different than the others. Most of the rocks were porous, but that larger one looked more consistently bubblier than the rest. It also glowed a bright white the closer the spirit stood near it.

“That’s it!” Nael yelled. Whatever that object was must be what was keeping the spirit from crossing over. He charged at Yoha, who was taken back, only to drop and grab the stone. Before the spirit could turn around, Nael dashed out of the observatory. He barred the doors from the outside using boards and a portable nail gun sitting ready nearby.

Nael pulled out his cellphone, still recording audio, and talked into it. Panting heavily. “I think this weird

thunder stone thing needs to be destroyed in order to defeat this ghost baddie. For now. Yoha is trapped in the observatory.”

But Nael felt a very cold tap on his shoulder.

“Guess again,” Yoha said. “Either you face me, or I will collect the heads of everyone in this city instead.”

He did not turn to look, or respond to the threat. Instead, he ran towards the parking lot. Screaming and hollering as loud as he could. Lights all over the town turned out, leaving everyone in total darkness. The earth began to shake.

“By morning!” Yoha yelled to the still running coward. “Either you fight me by tomorrow, or else!”



House near the Observatory

The brick flew inside the house, smashing the front door windows. Nael looked into the dark house at the pieces of broken glass covering the entryway. He let himself inside.

“No one was home, so I broke in!” Nael yelled. “My phone stopped working and I can’t get anything on the

radio... Is anyone here?”

When he felt sure that he was alone, he ventured further into the house. Checking every electronic device and light switch. Tv, toaster, laptop, and refrigerator full of carrot juice all were dead. Along with the landline still installed in the home.

“I have to find a way to destroy this stone before this gets any worse.”

Nael found his way to the garage and tried using all the tools he could find to break apart the stone. But no matter what he used, hammers and saws, it eventually chipped the metal. The thunder stone did not even contain a scratch.

“There has to be something stronger I can use. Acid, something!” he said.

For a long time he searched the garage, through old boxes of quilts and magazines. After moving a box on a lower shelf near the table saw, Nael smelled something. He followed his nose.

“Is that gunpowder?”

The source of the smell was a box labeled ‘fireworks’. He looked inside, finding dozens of roman candles and bottle

rockets. He dug in, and when he saw them his jaw dropped.

“Those are m-80’s! Those aren’t even legal! Score!”

Tying all the fuses together, he wrapped the thunder stone in explosives and went to the back yard lit only in moonlight. He placed the stone on the ground, lit the fuse and ran back into the house.

The first M-80 went off, shaking loose the dishes over the sink. The rest of them began to explode, sending chunks of dirt flying every where.

When the dust had cleared, he went back out. With his fingers crossed, hoping that the stone had been destroyed. Alas, at the bottom of a new hole created by the old fireworks, was the thunder stone. Still fully in tact. It is at that moment it hit Nael how much trouble he was in.

“There’s no way to destroy it. Oh man, I screwed up big time uh?”

A voice came from the front of the house. “Who are you! What are you doing in my parents house!”

Nael threw up his hands. “Yo bro, chill it’s just me...”

“STOP CALLING ME BRO!” His ex shouted walking out the back door. “Why are you here! The power is out all the way to Kansas City! People are freaking out everywhere and YOU ARE BREAKING INTO MY PARENTS HOUSE??? Destroying windows, breaking dishes, and what ever the flipping Thomas you are doing with my dad’s fireworks! I know the answer to this, but are you insane Nael!”

“No, I’m just dumb.” He said. “I challenged the undead and Yoha the Beheader is not being cool about it. He won’t cross over, and I tried to blow up the thunder stone he came from. I can’t defeat him. The power is going to be out until I face him.”

His ex inspected the hole in the ground, shaking her head. “That’s NOT a thunder stone. That is a Meteorite that I found when I was doing that paper on the Oregon Trail. I followed the worn road for a way when I found it. I gave it to the observatory so they could study in astronomy 101.”

“Yo, check I know I’m wrong like 49 percent of the time. But that is a thunder stone. Remember one of us failed geology? And that was not me. Main point is, this is your fault after all! You released a deadly ghost, this wouldn’t have happened if you would have skipped your homework and...”

He stopped. She folded her arms, waiting for the next words to come out of his mouth.

“There I go again. Being evil uh?” he sighed.

“You aren’t evil.” His ex said. “That black and white kind of thinking is half your problem anyway. That’s part of why, to quote the famous philosopher ‘we are never ever ever getting back together.’ But unlike stuff between us? You should face this.”

Something he had heard lit up his eyes. An idea came to mind. “We are never getting back together. That’s it. The solution has been in front of me all along!”

“What?” His ex asked. “You’re going to therapy?”

“Even better and cheaper!” Nael yelled. “I have to do to it what you did to me.”

His ex shook his head. “Don’t break up with the killer samurai ghost the way you broke up with me if that is what you mean.”

“No! You didn’t defeat me. Cure me. Or destroy me. Pastor Branson was right all along. Evil can’t be destroyed. It can only be pacified. You pacified me. Not out of spite, but out of care. Look, I need you. Round up everyone in town. Bring ballons, drinks, cake everything

you can get your hands on. Get everyone to Morrison Observatory! Before it's too late!"



Morrison Observatory

With held breath and sweating uncontrollably, Nael walked to the centre of the room and picked up a sword.

"This might be it for me. All she wrote." He said aloud to himself. "I can't help feel like I should have done more in my time. I wasted so much time wrapped up in my own B.S. I wish I could have learned how to love someone instead of secretly beating myself up all day."

There was no time for any of his last regrets. Yoha the spirit appeared in front of him. "You surprise me, I did not think you had the courage to return."

Nael raised his sword. The metal was met with the great Samurai's swing. His sword went flying across the room.

The warrior scoffed. "You are pathetic. Pick up your weapon. And let us agree to this new condition. If you win, I shall attempt to 'cross over' as you wish. My presence to be gone from these lands. Come on! Let us

end this.”

Nael looked at the sword on the other side of the room. He thought for along moment. Maybe there was a way he could defeat the spirit after all. If he could only get him in a moment of weakness. But he was no match for a trained killing machine. Not only that, but as he looked at the ghost standing there full of rage and anger, he saw someone else in his mind. That person being his ex. Maybe he could find a weakness and expose it. But how would he be any different of a person?

“You have already won,” Nael said. “You have proven your worth a thousand times over. I am no match for you. I concede the fight.”

Yoha laughed. “That is not how I fight.”

Nael walked to the door and opened it. “Come outside with me. I have something to show you. If you still want to stab me after, then I will let you.”

The spirit nodded, and followed him outside. There they were both met to a chorus of mighty cheers. Yoha the Beheader stood dumbstruck at the sight of everyone in the town standing around the observatory. Some held signs that read ‘we love you’. Other said things such as ‘The Warrior CMU deserves!’

Yoha turned to him and demanded to know. “What is the meaning of this? And what is that there? The large flat canvas?”

Nael walked in front of the spirit. “That is what we call a bouncy castle. We can’t inflate it right now, because your awesome power has shut off the power. But you are the most powerful, amazing force any of us have ever seen. Isn’t that right everyone?”

Everyone cheered. Except one person who shouted out “Well it’s close, but I stood close next to Ann Hathaway once...”

Someone shouted, “Shut the hell up Mike!”

Nael signed for the balloons and banner to be revealed.

“Yoha, the great. We are no match for you. That is why you should be the one we can rely on. The only one we can trust when times are the darkest. You told me you had a dream to unite your lands. But that was taken from you. And I think that sucks! That’s is why I think you are the only one who can save us from ourselves. Yoha the Beheader. Will you be our protector of Morrison Observatory?”

The warrior took a moment. He scanned looking at

everyone, squinting at every sign.

“I do not understand what is drawn upon those signs. English mastered I have not.” He bowed his head. “Wipe off your war paint and come talk to me. Thee who have challenged me.”

Nael looked around before shrugging. “I don’t understand. I’m not wearing war paint. Or makeup? None of us are?”

The warrior’s eye brow rose sharply. “You mean... you are not painted to blind me as an unfair advantage? You’re all just. That pale?”

Everyone nodded.

The warrior sighed.

“The sun defeated you long before I ever could have. You all are so weak and sad.”

Everyone nodded.

Yoha began to cry. “All I wanted was peace. To see my children and our friends be allowed a chance to live a fair life. We worked hard growing our tea in harsh conditions. It’s not fair that others are born in a land along the ocean! I see now that it wasn’t their fault. We were only

taught to blame all our problems on others. Because those who lead us need us not to question anything. I understand now. I accept this honour. I will behead anyone you wish.”

There was an awkward murmur in the crowd.

Nael raised his hand. “I mean. Sure if that ever was needed. But we were thinking more like. You could help watch the place. Maybe be a tutor some students on how the earth is the centre of the galaxy or something.”

Yoha shook his head. “No. That would be the sun. You should read a book. Or actually go watch the stars at this observatory! Your understanding of the solar system is shameful.”

“We are totally stoked you are doing this,” Nael said. “Let’s hear it for Yoha the Protector!”

Everyone cheered, and began to sing in union ‘Happy days are here again’.



CMU, the next morning.

“Yo preacher.” Nael typed on his phone. “No need to worry about the ghost. He’s chill and really good at

astronomy. His first study session went well. I'm also deleting the video I made about your cow racing ring. I don't agree with what you are doing. But at least you are doing it for a good cause. I still think stuff you are doing is shady, and you didn't seem to age at all in any of those photos I saw you from '96. Either way, If you ever need a video on something, hit me up. Peace."

He hit send. The phone chirped.

"Boy, do I have a great video to put together about this experience." He said aloud. As if narrating for too long had rotted his brain to the point he felt it normal to talk to himself repeatedly.

Before he could dwell on that thought for long, he received a call. It was from "Don't Apologise."

"Hi." Said a voice on the other end of the line. "This is Dave with Bergtolk and Sanders. I was given this number as a personal reference for..."

"Yeah bro! She is like an apple tree. You put her in a good environment and you are going to get some very good results. She worked on some video's for me, and even when stuff is impossible she finds a way to make it work. If you hire her and ever find you have problems with her ever, look in the mirror first. And you'll find her biggest

problem right there. Hire this chick bro. You'll thank me later."

"Oh., I... okay. Thank you for your time." The man hung up.

"Cool beans." Nael said out loud, turning towards the sunrise appearing on the horizon.

He smiled. "And now. I edit."

THE END.